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# Beyond the everyday? Rethinking place meanings in tourism

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## ABSTRACT

Existing tourism scholarship on place meanings seems to retain an underlying assumption of a contradiction between tourist places and the mundane world. In contrast, this paper contends that the production of the meanings of tourist places is also closely related to everyday life. To make its case, it interrogates the creation of meanings of two scenic sites of *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan in Sanya, a famous coastal destination in southern China. Although both scenic sites have been recently developed, their significance stems from historical and cultural meanings in traditional Chinese culture, which are frequently communicated in people's daily conversations and practices. Besides, the meanings of the tourist sites are neither fixed by legitimate discourses nor dominated by tourism publicity; they are continuously shaped by wider socio-spatial events in mundane societies and re-interpreted through tourism mobilities in accordance with tourists' everyday concerns. This paper echoes the 'new mobilities turn' in tourism studies and contributes to the discussions of the mundaneness of tourist places.

## 摘要

现有旅游研究似乎一直有一个潜在的假设，旅游地方与世俗世界存在冲突。与此相反，本文认为旅游地方意义的生产与日常生活密切相关。为了证明这个观点，本文调查了中国南部著名海滨旅游目的地三亚的天涯海角和南山两个旅游区的意义生产。尽管两个旅游区的都是最近才开发，但是他们的价值都源于中国传统文化中的历史文化意义。这种历史文化意义经常在人们日常谈话与实践中交流。另外，这两个旅游区的意义既不被正统的话语所限定的，也不被旅游宣传所主导。他们不断地被世俗社会中的社会事件所塑造，同时被与旅游者日常关切密切相关的旅游移动性所反复解读。本文呼应了旅游研究中的‘新移动转向’，并且有助于讨论旅游地方的日常性。

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## 1. Introduction

The building, advertisement and marketing of tourist places, among other things, are a fundamental strategy in the tourism industry. Britton (1991) notes that tourism, as prominent economic practices, has affected capital accumulation and competition in different regions. It has been widely deemed as an effective way to encourage new investment, increase revenue and facilitate socio-economic development in different areas. Under the

dominance of tourism economy, many places are fetishized as products and promoted as tourist attractions, satisfying the demand of international and regional visitors (e.g. Baylina & Berg, 2010; Costa & Besio, 2011; Hultman & Hall, 2012). Like any commodities, tourist places are packaged, advertised and sold to potential visitors for profit. In line with the understanding of tourism as an escape from modern life, they are likened to exotic and remote enclaves in prevailing representations and made into a fantasy world that inspires public imagination (cf. Brown, 2013; Lau, 2010). The distinction between tourist places and mundane societies is the underlying tenet of tourism marketing and promotion, and also a widespread assumption in much tourism scholarship.

In contrast with this understanding, this paper contends that the meanings of tourist places should not be simply attributed to the abnormal and extraordinary but are also constructed and communicated in mundane life. The everyday is characterized by seemingly routinized and banal activities, conventions and experiences but substantially influences individuals' behaviors, identities and comprehension, among others (Roberts, 2006). Tourism is considered as part of everyday life (Edensor, 2007; Haldrup & Larsen, 2010) and the 'otherness' of tourist places is viewed as rather problematic in consonance with the 'new mobilities turn' in the social sciences (Hannam, Urry, & Sheller, 2006; Sheller & Urry, 2006). This paper foregrounds and demonstrates the production and consumption of the meanings of tourist places in relation with their everyday significance by shedding light on two well-known scenic sites, *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone and the Nanshan cultural tourism zone, both located in Sanya, a famous coastal destination in southern China. The analysis reveals that different connotations attached to the scenic sites are generated and conveyed in history and deeply rooted in everyday culture (cf. Connell & Rugendyke, 2010). They are also shown to be mediated in tourism mobilities and re-interpreted by tourists according to their significance to people's daily lives. Tourism mobilities compose and unmake tourism, tourist places and the relations between people and places (cf. Sheller & Urry, 2004).

In the next section, we examine recent research on representations of tourist places, arguing that many discussions seem to maintain the contrast between tourist places and the mundane world. This is followed by the introduction of the field site of Sanya and the research methods. Subsequently, we demonstrate how the image of Sanya is created as a geographical, political, social and cultural margin in history. The imaginary of the remoteness of Sanya in traditional Chinese culture exerts considerable influence on the construction of place images of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone and Nanshan cultural tourism zone. Thereafter, we explore the meaning making of the two sites, initiated by the government and facilitated in wider social contexts. It is found that their meanings are closely related to people's everyday concerns. We further examine the re-production of authorized representations by tourists and tour guides through mobilities. The embodied touristic travel enables the renegotiation of meanings of *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan. This paper concludes with the reflection on the meanings of tourist places and their everyday significance, echoing the mobilities turn in tourism studies.

## 2. Creating the meanings of tourist places

Tourist places are subject to economic production and consumption. In the tourism industry, Britton (1991) claims that place images need to be standardized in order to be

'explicitly incorporated into the accumulation process' (p. 451). Apart from different tourism corporations and operators, governments actively participate in representing and promoting destination through policy making, planning, advertisement campaigns, exhibitions, publicity and the like (e.g. Geary, 2013). The creation of a series of place images often becomes a pivotal strategy to stimulate people's desire to visit and for different destinations to succeed in fierce competition with one another. For Salazar (2012), '[i]t is hard to think of tourism without imaginaries or 'fantasies'' (p. 865). Young (1999) contends that "what is marketed is not a particular place or product, but rather a projected interpretation or mediated image of a place' (p. 375). Edensor elaborates further,

Representations are integral to tourism and the tourist industry. Symbols, images, signs, phrases and narratives provide the ideas that fuel the commodification and consumption of tourist sites. Representations are disseminated by souvenirs, travel guides, postcards, travel accounts, photography, guidebooks, travel programmes and in a host of popular cultural forms including televised and cinematic drama, news bulletins and lifestyle magazines. (1998, p. 11)

The creation of place meanings in tourism is indeed selective and contested. For Davis (2005), places 'are the result of spatially wide-ranging regimes of power and the ability of some to legitimize one imagining of a place over others' (p. 609). Tourist places are never literally elaborated but partially demonstrated, with some features strongly highlighted and others disguised. In prevailing tourism discourses, tourist places are often represented as idiosyncratic and extraordinary so as to make them attractive. International tourism, for one thing, characterizes many destinations and their people as oriental, underdeveloped and exotic (e.g. d'Hauterres, 2011), and for another, privileges western identity (e.g. Bryce, 2012). Similarly, in regional and national contexts, the uniqueness of tourism destinations is fully demonstrated and marketed (e.g. McMorran, 2008). Sanya, for example, is widely publicized as a romantic tropical region and attracts numerous people from the mainland. In many contexts, tourism places are thought of as the opposite of modern societies, to which touristic travel becomes an escape and the pursuit of experiences that are notably absent from the everyday. The production of place meanings in the tourism industry is often associated with myth making, by which tourist places are differentiated and given a sense of mystique (Selwyn, 1996).

One prevailing assumption underpinning the production of myth is that tourists look for authenticity in tourism destinations. According to MacCannell (1976), the artificiality, intricacy and instantaneity of the modern world evoke people's nostalgia to search for 'pure,' 'simple' and 'real' lives in other places that are not yet spoiled by modernity. Tourism becomes an enactment to seek 'authentic' experiences and senses of places in 'non-western' societies, wherein lives and cultures are 'natural' and 'eternal.' For MacCannell (1976), modern tourists act like pilgrims on a sightseeing tour which 'possesses its own moral structure, a collective sense that certain sights must be seen' (p. 42). This theory appears highly insightful in its ability to understand touristic behaviors and socio-cultural representations of tourist places. However, it seems to reinforce dichotomies of the inauthentic and real, the variable and stable, and the modern and primitive that distinguish 'western' societies from 'non-western' tourism destinations.

Rather than assuming a given and objective authenticity, Cohen (1988) contends that the 'authentic' is socially constructed in tourists' own cultural systems and continuously

negotiated in tourism. He views authentic experiences as 'emergent authenticity,' which is gradually recognized by tourists over time. The social construction of authenticity has indeed been frequently used as an effective strategy to create brands of different tourism destinations (e.g. Connell & Rugendyke, 2010; Costa & Besio, 2011). In the case of Sanya, the government contrives to modify 'authentic' images of tourist sites and influence tourism consumption, while many tourists concern their original meanings that are constructed in traditional Chinese culture.

In contrast with objective and constructive authenticity, many scholars argue that the authentic is experienced and performed (Brown, 2013; Steiner & Reisinger, 2006; Zhu, 2012). Wang (1999) proposes the concept of 'existential authenticity' and explores the 'authentic' originating from inter-subjective and emotional experience. That is, authenticity is realized through intra-personal feeling and inter-personal interaction and associated with the construction of subjectivity. Individuals' sentiments, experiences, affects substantially influence people's perception of the 'real' and 'authentic' (Mura, 2015; Zhu, 2012). Brown (2013) further argues that existential authenticity is not merely constructed during holiday and that tourism is a catalyst for 'the adoption of an authentic life beyond the trip' (p. 179). In this paper, tourists' understanding of 'real' meanings of scenic sites in Sanya changes through tourism mobilities. The academic disputes about objective, constructive and existential authenticity illustrate the production of place meanings including myth in tourism.

Although place meanings are filtered and constructed by the government and tourism industry, tourists are by no means passive receivers of sanctioned images and simply confined to certain ways of consuming 'authentic' places and people. Place meanings are not merely imposed by economic restructuring and marketing, but created and embedded in individuals' memories, anticipation, imagination, practices, cultural values and social networks (cf. Ku, 2011; Thurnell-Read, 2012). In Chang (2010)'s study of architourism in Malaysia and Singapore, tourists have their own ways to consume place meanings and appreciate vernacular architecture styles of historical boutique hotels as an authentic experience of local culture. Examining safari tourism in East Africa, Norton (1996) notes that tourists are capable of making evaluations and changing future touristic consumption via the self-reflection of tourism experience. The re-interpretation of tourist places made by visitors sometimes even contradicts authorized representations. In a study of tourism in Romania by Light (2007), although the state contrives to establish a new image of the country beyond the mystic illusion of Dracula, tourists visualize and interpret the significance of places in their own ways. Rather than assigned by dominant discourses, place meanings emerge in tourism mobilities and are modified in all sorts of ways by different people (cf. Bærenholdt, 2004; Salazar, 2012). The active initiatives of tourists in interpreting scenic sites pose huge challenges for governments, planners and the tourism industry to maintain a unique destination image, which is evident in the case study of Sanya.

In addition to the discussion of authenticity and tourists' agency, the construction of place meanings is also examined in wider socio-spatial contexts. In this study of destination development in Sweden, Hultman and Hall (2012) argue that place making is contextualized and facilitated by a variety of mundane practices. Davis (2005) avers that the 'place-myth generated for a given site may have much more to do with stories and images of other places deemed to be "like" it than with the landscape of the place itself' (p. 612). In practice, many destinations often learn from others' successful experiences and deploy

similar approaches and techniques of planning, management and marketization. In most cases, the meaning construction is embedded in broader political networks. Tourism development including the production of place images is often incorporated into state governance and social advancement. Oakes and Sutton (2010) assert that, besides the generation of revenue, leisure consumption in China is closely related to state-sponsored projects of cultivating 'civilized' citizens and improving the 'quality' of the population. Hence, Favero (2000) contends that tourism experiences and place images are 'culturally shaped and contextually situated' (p. 1) and should be examined in specific contexts.

In spite of the systematic and dialectical reflection on place meanings, many analyses seem to retain the underlying assumption of the contradiction between tourist places and the mundane world. Whereas it has been acknowledged that the significance of tourist places is produced by various agents including the government and tourists and constantly changes in tourism mobilities, much tourism scholarship mainly concentrates on the marketization, management and commercialization of tourism destinations, and resonates with the dominant public image of the separation of tourist places and everyday society. This paper contends that it is unreliable to exaggerate the differentiation of tourist places, and their meanings are also linked to everyday life. For example, the consumption of tourist places can be connected to an array of purposes such as education, entertainment and the development of family and cultural identity (Gruffudd, Herbert, & Piccini, 1999). Although some studies acknowledge the influence of wider social processes on the production of place meanings in tourism, the mundaneness of tourist places is implicitly and subconsciously discussed. By contrast, this paper seeks to foreground the relations of place meanings and the everyday by the study of Sanya.

### 3. Field site and research methods

Sanya is located at 18°09' N latitude, a southernmost city of Hainan Island in the South China Sea (see Figure 1). It is the second-largest city in Hainan, with an area of about 1,918 km<sup>2</sup> and approximately 700,000 permanent residents. Since the end of the 20<sup>th</sup> century, it has grown into the most popular coastal resort in the country. Tourism and real estate, considered the backbone of the local economy, offer large-scale employment and attract major investments. According to the Sanya Tourism Development Commission, Sanya received more than 13.5 million over-night visitors in 2014, of whom 97% are Chinese. In other words, it is largely a domestic tourism destination despite advertisement of it as a pioneering international resort in China. The structure of tourism market exerts considerable influence on how meanings of tourist sites in Sanya are constructed, interpreted and communicated. In this paper, the production and consumption of two scenic sites are closely related to traditional Chinese culture and everyday concerns of contemporary domestic visitors.

The two scenic sites selected are *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone and Nanshan cultural tourism zone, both of which are located at the west of the downtown area. *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone, covering about 20 km<sup>2</sup> area, was built in 1984 and is one of the earliest authorized tourist sites in Hainan. As will be demonstrated later, it is the best known tourist attraction in Sanya because of the significance of the term *Tianya Haijiao* in traditional culture. Although this site is only established as a four-star-awarded attraction<sup>1</sup> by the China National Tourism Administration, it is the symbolic of Sanya and its second most-



**Figure 1.** Location of Sanya.

visited scenic site, receiving 3.48 million tourists in 2013. In comparison, Nanshan cultural tourism zone covers an area of 50 km<sup>2</sup>, and has been developed since 1995. It is well known in Hainan and was awarded one of the first five-star scenic sites in China in 2007. In 2013, it received 3.88 million visitors, making it the most popular attraction in Sanya. Apart from their prominence and fame in Sanya tourism, both places represent two kinds of cultural landscapes developed in different time along with socio-economic transformation of this coastal destination. The selection and analysis of the two sites offer a valuable perspective to explore the relations between the construction of the meanings of tourist places and everyday life.

This paper is derived from a large project undertaken between 2014 and 2015, which investigated tourism mobilities and everyday life in Sanya. In this paper, we mainly draw on online and print publicity materials to explore the history and authorized representation of two scenic sites. Online data was attained from official websites of the local government and companies of both tourism zones. Tourism brochures, leaflets and other publicity materials of Sanya tourism, collected from the government and local tourism agencies, were carefully scrutinized as well. These data greatly enrich information over a long-time span on the place making of Sanya and two scenic sites, which may not be easily and directly obtained by interview and observation.

Secondary data analysis is further assisted by semi-structured interview. Derived from the large project, we include 21 interviews with domestic sightseeing tourists ( $n = 15$ ) and tour guides ( $n = 6$ ) in this paper; all informants are anonymous. Tourists were met and interviewed in scenic sites while tour guides were contacted in advance.



The interviews with tourists focus on how visitors consume tourist places and cover questions about their tourism experiences, practices and interpretations of these two sites. Tour guides were invited to share their understandings of place meanings of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone and Nanshan cultural tourism zone as well as how they carry out their work in these places.

#### 4. Sanya on the fringe of Chinese society

Sanya was previously considered as a remote area, the history and images of which were marked by the marginalization of Hainan Island in the country. This island is in the South China Sea and had not been influenced by orthodox Chinese culture for a long time. According to the *Chronicles of Yazhou* (Zhang, Xing, Zhao, & Guo, 1983), the first emperor of the Qin Dynasty declared his rule over this island in 214 BC. It was not until Emperor Wu (156 BC–87 BC) of the Han Dynasty set up two local government institutions that Hainan was the first time under the power of the central state. One administrative center was later called *Yazhou*, which then became a major political center in Hainan in different dynasties. Although the scope of *Yazhou* often changed in history and was hard to be identified today, some people claim it was located in present Sanya. Nonetheless, it was very difficult for the central state to govern the distant southern island in ancient time. The poor connection between Hainan and the mainland has been maintained in a long period of time. According to Yan (2013), most ancient regimes adopted passive strategies to govern Hainan and did not undertake major reform to change the local society. Many places on the island like Sanya were largely ignored by the government and remained unchanged in different eras (Atsushi, 1979).

The geographical separation and socio-political marginalization have ultimately resulted in the remoteness of Hainan including Sanya in traditional Chinese culture. For people in the mainland, the conventional image of this isolated island always conjured up illusions of wildness and savagery (Yan, 2013). In historical records and literature, Hainan is described as a dangerous area with distinctive and extreme natural environment of hot temperature, wild animals and fatal diseases. It was traditionally represented as primeval, uncivilized and backward. Because of that, Hainan became a preferred place to expel criminals in ancient China. Many exiled people were previous senior bureaucrats who were demoted and came to this place because they either had failed in political struggles or had infuriated emperors. Yan and Liu (2011) point out that exile to Hainan had become prominent since the Tang Dynasty (681 AD–907 AD). A large number of people were sent to *Yazhou* and most of them had never come back. Many banished officials were well-known poets, calligraphers and literati, and they left many poems and writings about their lives, experiences, sentiments and aspirations in this place, according to which *Yazhou* was a horrible place at the end of the world where there was no hope and future. For example, Yan Yang, a former Prime Minister in the Tang Dynasty, wrote the following poem in exile,

This is a long trip, thousands of li<sup>2</sup> away from home,  
 Numerous people go there while nobody return.  
 Where is Yazhou?  
 I am passing by the gate of the hell when I am alive.



This poetry conveys strong emotions of the poet's despair and fosters the illusion of alienation of this place. Like Yang, most demoted officials suffered severe depression due to their confinement, and wrote poems and articles to express their frustration, desperation and misery. Their literary works were widely disseminated around the country due to their political and cultural prestige and the literati's sympathy with their sufferings. As such, the negative rhetoric and imaginary about *Yazhou* were continuously reproduced in a myriad of literature later, and *Yazhou* became symbolic of the remote and hopeless in traditional Chinese culture. The history of exile coincided with and consolidated the long-established impression of Hainan as being on the edge of Chinese society.

In official publicity, Sanya brands itself as the original *Yazhou*. This claim is widely accepted by tourists due to its history, geography and relatively underdeveloped economy in China. Sanya was never an important place name and seldom known by people in history, and had not been founded as a municipal city until 1987. This city had yet not been the main focus of social and economic development of Hainan for many years after the establishment of People's Republic of China. Even today, its socio-economic development largely lags behind that of many mainland cities. The combination of Sanya with *Yazhou*, on the one hand, makes this new city quickly known by most Chinese people and facilitates tourism growth, and on the other hand, reinforces the myth and public illusions of the marginality of Sanya. The production and consumption of place meanings of many tourist sites in city are influenced by such cultural imagination, which is especially attractive to Chinese tourists. Take *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone and Nanshan tourism zone for example. While the local government makes full use of such image and facilitates brand building of these sites, it also seeks to diminish negative impacts of the remote *Yazhou* by highlighting the mundane importance of these attractions. As for tourist consumption, the time-honored history of *Yazhou*, traditional Chinese culture and tourists' everyday concerns lead to the re-interpretation and particular ways of consuming these scenic sites.

## 5. *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan in the imaginary

In Chinese idioms, the term *Tianya Haijiao* often evokes images of the remoteness, inaccessibility and mystery. It can be literally understood as the margin of heaven (*Tianya*) and the extreme of the sea (*Haijiao*), and implies faraway places at the end of the world. Imaginations of *Tianya Haijiao* conform to ancient Chinese people's view of the earth that is claimed to be bounded and covered by heaven. The illusion is repeated in literary creations, and gradually associated with Hainan Island due to its symbolism in traditional culture. *Yazhou* shares the same Chinese character and meaning of *Ya* with *Tianya*; it was conventionally linked to the actual location of *Tianya Haijiao*. On top of the illusion of the remoteness of *Tianya Haijiao*, this Chinese idiom has moved beyond historical memories of the despair and misery of demoted officials in *Yazhou*. In everyday life, it is now broadly used to convey emotions of homesickness, love to parents, siblings, lovers and friends, and persistence to do something.

The imaginary of *Tianya Haijiao* is at present concretized in the *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone in Sanya. There are many inscriptions in Chinese characters on some large seaside rocks in this scenic site, which have been left by historical figures in the last two to three hundred years. These inscriptions coincide with the geographical location of Sanya and the socio-cultural marginality of *Yazhou* fostered in history and everyday culture.

Thus they constitute the most powerful evidence to justify the legitimacy of this site as the original record of *Tianya Haijiao* apart from many other ambiguous tales and literature. According to the homepage of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone ([www.aitianya.cn](http://www.aitianya.cn)), one pivotal rock with the writing of *Tianya* was inscribed by the head of *Yazhou* government in 1727, and another two characters, *Haijiao*, were carved on an adjacent rock by a commander of a garrison in Hainan during the anti-Japanese war. In this way, the rich meanings of *Tianya Haijiao* were assigned to the two inscribed rocks in this place. Moreover, Chinese tourists tend to use *Tianya Haijiao* as the abbreviation of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone, which further obscures this site and the imaginary *Tianya Haijiao*.

Similarly, place meanings of Nanshan cultural tourism zone take advantage of the cultural significance of *Nanshan* and the marginal imagination of Sanya. Literally, *Nanshan* is composed of two Chinese characters *Nan* (south) and *Shan* (mountain) and denotes the South Mountain. Ancient Chinese people believed that mountains were holy and mysterious places, wherein gods and sages stay. Almost all famous mountains in China are associated with myths, and some of them are sacred places of Buddhism and Taoism. In history, seeking seclusion in famous mountains is viewed as a lofty lifestyle of people with great esteem and wisdom, and their stories and literature have inspired rich imaginations of later generations. *Nanshan* is a spiritual mountain, wherein all creatures are claimed to have a long life, and is traditionally associated with longevity (*Changshou*). This place name has been repeated in numerous poems, prose, fiction, tales and the like, and similar to *Tianya Haijiao*, it carries enormous significance in Chinese culture. In everyday context, it is common to see people use *Nanshan* to bless the elderly on their birthday. As an old saying goes, '*Fu ru Donghai, shou bi Nanshan*' (the bliss is as great as the East China Sea, the longevity is as much as the South Mountain).

Like *Tianya Haijiao*, it is hard to identify an original location of the imaginary *Nanshan* today, and in China, many mountains are given this name according to some piece of historical records, literature and even tales. One mountain in Sanya is quickly known as the 'real' *Nanshan* through different publicity, marketing campaigns and tourism practices. It is argued that, if we look from above, the shape of *Nanshan* in Sanya resembles that of a huge turtle (*Bie*) lying at the seaside. In Chinese culture, the turtle is a sacred animal and the symbol of longevity. Apart from this analogy, its significance as the original *Nanshan* is underpinned by the remoteness of Sanya and its symbolic association with Buddhism. The South China Sea, by which Sanya locates, is a holy land in Buddhism. In official publicity ([www.nanshan.com](http://www.nanshan.com)), it is said that Guanyin, the esteemed Buddha of mercy and wisdom, made twelve wishes in order to give universal blessings to all living creatures. The second wish was to take up permanent residence in the South China Sea. In addition, many relevant tales of the close link between *Nanshan* in Sanya and Buddhism are widely advertised by the local government and tourism industry. These 'evidences' and explanations appear rather convincing for tourists in the context of the geographical, historical and cultural alienation of Sanya, making this site mystery.

Hence, the place meanings of tourist sites of *Tianya Haijiao* and *Nanshan* are deeply rooted in traditional culture that is embedded in everyday practices and communicated by the ordinary people. This echoes to DeLyser (1999)'s study of the ghost town in California, the image of which is created in local and national media and rooted in everyday culture. In many cases, it is the nostalgia for and imagination of time-honored Chinese culture, rather than seaside landscapes, that draw tourists to visit these scenic sites.

For example, many informants complain that tourism experience in *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone is below expectation because its coastal view and architecture are similar to those of other seaside areas. Ms. Zhou, a mainland tourist, argues that '*Tianya Haijiao* is nothing special without those rocks and symbolic meanings.' In spite of that, a number of tourists continue to visit this place for its great cultural significance. As Ms. Yao claims, 'I have looked forward to visiting *Tianya Haijiao* for a long time. It is so famous! The margin of heaven and the extreme of the sea!' For Mr. Zhen who has never travelled to Sanya before, the only place he must visit in Sanya is *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone, even though the physical landscape and tour experience in this site may not be so unique. 'It is cool, man! Image that you act like ancient sages and come to the edge of heaven; that is fantastic! I like the feeling!'

## 6. Making tourist places in mundane society

The making of *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan as popular tourism zones is closely related to the social and economic development in contemporary China. For example, *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone has already been well known among the Chinese long before the tourism prosperity in Sanya. Among other things, two events in the 1980s after the economic reform are especially worth noting. In 1982, a new song, *Welcome to Tianya Haijiao* quickly gained popularity in the context of the growth of pop music in the country. It highlights the tropical landscape of this place, romanticizes its traditional imaginary, and succeeds in arousing the curiosity of the public. Two years afterwards, this song was sung in the spring festival gala, the important official New Year celebration held by China Central Television, which made it widely accessible by Chinese people. The fame of this scenic spot spread further in the aftermath of the fourth edition of RMB in 1987. The image of *Nan Tian Yi Zhu* (the pillar rock of south heaven) in this site was featured on the back of the 2 Yuan<sup>3</sup> note (see Figure 2), thus embedding it in a variety of people's everyday activities. In this way, this place became well known to the Chinese people and nowadays, *Tianya Haijiao* has been another name of Sanya. In our investigation, most tourists can readily mention *Tianya Haijiao* as a Sanya attraction, even those who visit this city for the first time.



Figure 2. The back of the 2 Yuan note in the fourth edition of RMB (photo taken by the author).

The local government, among many other agents, plays a key role in creating the meanings of both places. The development of the Nanshan cultural tourism zone started with the construction of the Nanshan Buddhist temple with the support from the government in 1995; before that, this place has been merely a normal coastal zone covered by boundless forests. In 1999, a year after the completion of the temple construction, the local government facilitated building a 108-meter-high Guanyin statue in the South China Sea. The massive statue is now the world's largest Guanyin statue in the sea, and adds considerably to this site, which has gained nationwide reputation of a holy Buddhist land.

Like the promotion of Buddhist culture in Nanshan, the government pays great attention to the connection of place meanings of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone and people's daily concerns. It tries to direct tourists' gaze on the positive connotations of this site and to divert it any negative associations so as to maintain its attractiveness. One important strategy is to highlight the blessing of love, conveyed by everyday usage of *Tianya Haijiao* in contemporary China, and conceal the historical implication of the end of life. People often compare the eternity of love to the trip to *Tianya Haijiao*, which means lovers accompany each other and stay together until the end of their lives. The symbolic trip to *Tianya Haijiao* is mobilized and simplified by tourism marketing and interpreted as romantic travel to this tourist site. This strategy is rather appealing to many young people, who usually travel with their boyfriends or girlfriends to this seaside city. Since 1996, *Tianya* international wedding festival has been held each year, at which it is reported that dozens of new couples celebrate their marriage. This place is also promoted as a great setting for wedding photography, which reinforces the authorized image of romance. Meanwhile, other tourism publicity materials seek to replace any 'undesirable' connotations of *Tianya Haijiao* such as the implication of the end of life with some 'appealing' cultural meanings. In the *Sanya guide book for travelers (2013)* published by Sanya Tourism Development Commission, the significance of iconic rocks of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone is reinterpreted with good wishes of love, wealth, fortune and safety, which most Chinese people are happy to hear.

*Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone is the landmark of Sanya. Nowadays, this scenic site has been endowed with new connotations on the ground of its traditional cultural significance. 'Love rock' is located in the sea and faces the gate. 'Nan Tian Yi Zhu', the image of which can be seen on the back of the 2 Yuan note is also called 'Wealth Rock'. 'Fortune Rock' is previous 'Haijiao Rock' and indicates good luck forever, while 'Tianya Rock' is now named 'Safety Rock', which, according to the legend, is a hundred million year old and the ancestor of all rocks in the South China Sea. 'Progress Rock' is next to 'Safety Rock', which implies promising study and career.

Although both tourist sites, as many other places in Sanya, were seldom known by many Chinese in history, their place images are effectively reconstructed and spread over the country after the tourism boom at the end of 1990s. Under the context of increasing regional tourism mobilities, the rich historical and cultural symbolism of the two sites is explored, packaged and advertised, and becomes main tourist attractions. However, the construction of place meanings is beyond the scope of tourism practices and publicity. As demonstrated above, it is strongly shaped by a variety of social, cultural, economic and political processes, and closely related to everyday life. Indeed, with the prevalence of cell-phones and new chat software in China, the fame of many tourist sites in Sanya is quickly spread by tourists through personal webpages and online social communities. In the

official advertisement, the mundane significance of both sites of *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan is frequently emphasized, which contrasts with the orthodox representation of coastal destinations as exotic and alien.

## 7. Reproducing place meanings in tourism mobilities

The authorized meanings of both tourist sites, however, are not fully accepted by tourists. While many tourists may be driven by the impulse to seek 'authentic' tourist sites in Sanya, their understanding of place meanings is substantially re-produced in embodied encounters and tourism practices. Through mobilities, tourists and tour guides have great capacity for the reconstruction of place images. In the case of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone, visitors are glad to accept good wishes such as the blessings of love, whereas the original association of this place with the misery of demoted officials has not together vanished. The history of exile in ancient *Yazhou* and the illusion of the death of hope are sometime reproduced by tour guides during the travel. Mr. Zhang, who has been a tour guide for three years, told me that his colleagues always develop their own commentaries based on some online samples. In one version of *Guide of Tianya Haijiao tourism zone* he provided, potential misfortunes related to this scenic site are strongly emphasized.

... Attention please! Some teammates may work as officials or business people. Before you come to Sanya, your friends must have told you that you should never go to *Tianya Haijiao* [tourism zone] so as to avoid misfortune. I have encountered this kind of tourists many times. Last time, one customer stubbornly refused to tour this site. He told me that one of his friends closed down his company after tourism in *Tianya Haijiao* [tourism zone]. So, if it were your first time to this place and you were either officials or business people, I would like to suggest you not to visit Haijiao [Rock] once you have seen Tianya [Rock], vice versa...Please leave some room for your life, and do not run into the cul-de-sac. That is the end of the earth! If you do not believe, then just do it. But I have to say that many people tend to believe it. If this is your second time, please do not go inside again but look at them from a distance. One time is enough! Why to experience the trip to *Tianya Haijiao* [i.e. the end of the world] a second time in your life?...

However, this does not mean that tour guides intend to oppose the dominant positive representations. In fact, it is more common to see that they introduce both authorized meanings such as the ever-lasting love as well as rumors of bad luck surrounding this place. One motivation for reproducing these 'secretes' around *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone, for many guides, is to catch people's attention. An experienced tour guide, Ms. Xie notes that 'we must say something that interests our customers; if we simply recite official discourses, they may not like us.' For her, the meanings of tourist sites do not make sense if they are not combined with tourists' daily concerns. Besides, not all tour guides include these warnings into their commentaries each time. In most situations, their 'serious' suggestions seem to be improvisation came up with different work circumstances and are used to establish their authority of local knowledge and develop trust between them and tourists.

The commentaries made by tour guides are not taken seriously by all visitors. In fact, many informants make fun of those rumors and tales surrounding this tourist site, and do not think they will be cursed as a result of visiting those rocks. Some tourists state that it is not uncommon to hear similar warnings in other tourist sites in China. For them, it is

almost inevitable to know these unfavorable stories because place meanings are complex and diversified. As such, they do not want to alter their journey because of some negative comments on *Tianya Haijiao*. The testimony of Ms. Qian who is on vacation with her boyfriend provides an appropriate illustration.

When we registered the package tour, we were attracted by its fame (i.e. *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone). Later, we learned some stories and rumors about this place. We searched online. Although some people claim that *Tianya Haijiao* means the end of good things and lovers should not visit it, others hold an opposite opinion and argue that it is a must-visit site for lovers. [...] I would rather accept the positive meaning.

However, the hint of misfortune actually troubles some other tourists and arouses the worry of bad luck. The made-up stories in tour trips are rationalized by tourists according to their own life experiences, beliefs, values and identities. For some people, tour guides' statements seem to be rather convincing because it is easy to find similar comments and gossips about *Tianya Haijiao* online and from their friends. For example, the tourist Mr. Hu told me that he had learned from his brother about this site, which is claimed to be ominous. Even though many visitors are not serious about these myths, they are inclined to believe tour guides in a certain degree. The opinion of Ms. Liu, a mainland tourist from Shenzhen, is rather typical.

Well, I am not familiar with Sanya. It is good to know and prepare for the worst. Anyway, I am a normal person and I can go to *Tianya Haijiao*. Our guide told us that people here invited a Fengshui master to offset the disadvantage of this site, which made it better than before. But many officials and businessmen will definitely not visit. The guide said that no senior officials of the central government came to this place and left some inscriptions while they did that in other less important tourist sites in Hainan. This is so strange!

For Ms. Liu, tour guides' introduction, to some degree, sounds reasonable. She claims that she does not see any inscriptions and photos of important politicians in this site while it is common to see them in other tourist places<sup>4</sup>. Thus, she tends to agree that many officials do not dare visit this place. Exemplified by the reproduction of the negative cultural connotations of *Tianya Haijiao* and tourists' unease about these, this paper contends that place meanings in tourism are continuously re-written while being combined with people's everyday concerns of good fortune and promising future.

This is also obvious when we observe tourist practices in the Nanshan cultural tourism zone wherein tourism and religion are integrated. In most situations, visitors take on dual identities as tourist and pilgrim. Their complicated practices are closely related to everyday life (cf. Chen & Chang, 2015; Edensor, 2007; Larsen, 2008) and effectively reshape the significance of this scenic site. Numerous faithful Buddhist believers from all over the world visit this place annually and conduct worship. A local tour guide Mr. Chen states, 'we received numerous pilgrims from over the world and in big festivals; it is difficult to find a place in the car park of Nanshan.' Ms. Yang is one of these pilgrims and traveled from Kunming, a city in southwest China, by car with her family. 'My son is in his annual leave and decides to bring the whole family to Sanya for vacation. He knows that I am a Buddhist and takes me to Nanshan. I am so happy to pray to Guanyin Buddha — the largest Guanyin status in the sea.' These pilgrims also tour inside this place, enjoy its beautiful seaside and mountainous landscapes and take photos for memory. After visiting this place, some of them join sightseeing tours and continue their vacation in this city.





**Figure 3.** Tourists praying outside a Buddhist temple (photo taken by the author).

For example, Ms. Yang told me that her family would spend four days in Sanya and visit two more cities in Hainan Island before going back to Kunming. For these pilgrim tourists, worship practices are indispensable components of everyday practices. The Buddha such as Guanyin enshrined in this tourist site is also widely worshipped in different areas in China including tourists' own home. In this sense, it is unrealistic to completely separate such tourists' practices in this place from those in the everyday environment.

Although the main purpose of many tourists, in contrast with pilgrims, is recreation, a number of them go to the Nanshan temple as well as other sacred spaces in this place to pray for themselves and family members when they travel in Sanya. Except for activities like taking photos and buying souvenirs, they purchase expensive incenses and candles, conduct worship and donate money to different temples (see [Figure 3](#)). Although some tourists do not think they are Buddhist believers, few people definitely deny the existence and power of gods. For many visitors, it is harmless to pray for the blessing of gods in this sacred place during the vacation. Mr. Xu, a mainland tourist, argues that 'people always say that you should worship the Buddha if you go to temples. Nanshan is a very famous temple in our country; why not we pray?' The opinions and behaviors of tourists, albeit impacted by the religious atmosphere in this site, do not just emerge here and disappear when they return home. Instead, these spiritual beliefs and embodied practices root in people's everyday conversation, value, activities and decision making (cf. Oakes & Sutton, 2010). For example, many Chinese people tend to select a good day based on lunar calendar when they plan to do important things thereby wishing good fortune.



For Vukonic (1996), '[p]eople have always had a spiritual life, [...] which existed even when people were not consciously aware of it, or at least were not aware of its meaning and were unable to discuss it' (p. 3).

In the case of Nanshan cultural tourism zone, its place images stem from traditional Chinese culture. They are also modeled and reproduced in tourism mobilities, and tourists selectively highlight the significance of this place in terms of their concerns about fortune, health and luck, among others. The simultaneity of touristic and religious practices create multiple and interlaced place meanings, which are interpreted and experienced in various ways by leisure seekers and religious adherents (cf. Bremer, 2004; Edensor, 1998). For people who pray in front of Buddha in this place, their worship is not exceptional performance; it conveys good wishes they are looking for in the everyday. Tourists strongly highlight the sacredness of Nanshan through their performances and commentaries, while the cultural implication of longevity of this place is relatively overshadowed.

## 8. Conclusion

This paper has explored the underlying relations between the (re)production of the meanings of tourist places and everyday life. Exemplified by analyses of tourist sites of *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan, the significance of these places is not simply invented in tourism campaign and publicity. Instead, it fundamentally roots in historical and cultural meanings which are frequently communicated and embedded in people's daily conversations and activities. The meanings of tourist places are created in relation with a variety of social, cultural, economic and political practices and events beyond tourism, and should be understood in relation with wider social contexts. In this paper, although the government and tourism industry contrive to confine place images to certain connotations and promote tourism consumption, place meanings in tourism are by no means fixed but continuously re-produced through touristic practices and interaction among different agents in tourism mobilities. The increase of tourism mobilities, for one thing, greatly stimulates the promotion of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone and Nanshan cultural tourism zone, and for another, substantially shapes the reconstruction of place meanings.

It is worth noting that the cases of *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan are not unique. In China, as well as many other places, the meanings of tourist sites are linked to the everyday in a certain degree. For example, the importance of many cultural heritages is realized in both tourism and many other everyday practices (see DeLyser, 1999). It is also important to note that this paper does not suggest that the two cases are representative of the construction of the meanings of tourist places in relation with mundane life. The analysis of both tourist sites provides a valuable perspective to illustrate rather than universalize such relations. Tourist places are multiple, dynamic and complex; their connections with everyday life vary across different time-spaces and should be analyzed in certain contexts. For example, foreign tourists may not grasp the everyday significance of both scenic sites in the same way as domestic visitors do. Likewise, some myths about Nanshan are conceived as jokes by many mainland tourists, but they greatly influence people with strong religious belief. In many contexts, it is relatively easy for visitors from a similar (sub-)cultural background to build up connections between the meanings of tourist places and their everyday conversations, learnings and activities. Such connections are also strengthened or weakened by tourism advertisements, individual biography and dominant social

values, among others. Although the specific evolution and place making of both tourism zones discussed in this paper may not fully represent those of many other scenic sites, they foreground how meanings of tourist places are (re)created in everyday societies, challenging the dominant representation of tourist places as exotic, mysterious and alien in marketing.

In this sense, this paper also echoes the de-differentiation of tourism in current tourism scholarship. In line with the 'new mobilities turn,' tourists can be understood as people who do social lives at a distance (Larsen, Urry, & Axhausen, 2007), while tourism, rather than being considered as an escape from the mundane life, is intrinsically linked to the everyday. As Cresswell (2004) argues, places are produced 'through the reiteration of practices – the repetition of seemingly mundane activities on a daily basis' (p. 82). The significance of *Tianya Haijiao* and Nanshan is re-interpreted and re-constructed by visitors according to their daily concerns. Tourist places are not conceived of the antithesis of mundane society but 'home away from home.' It is also worth noting that this paper does not assert that the meanings of tourist places have totally become banal and been dominated by its everyday significance. In fact, tourist sites are still made different in advertisement and marketing, and frequently represented as exotic in many contexts. By exploring the inter-connection between place meanings in tourism and everyday life, this paper contributes to the discussions of the mundaneness of tourist places.

## Notes

1. In China, tourist sites are categorized into star-rated and unauthorized scenic spots, and the best tourism attraction is given as five star rating by the government.
2. 1 Li is about 500 m.
3. 1 Yuan is about 0.16 US dollar.
4. According to the official website of *Tianya Haijiao* tourism zone, this place, like many other tourist sites, has received some important Chinese politicians. Many tourists do not spend time gaining these information by themselves, but rely on tour guides' introduction and their temporal experiences in this place.

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No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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